

■ Step-by-Step Guide: Butchering and Processing Meat Rabbits

■ Supplies Needed:

- 1 Killing tool (dispatcher/cervical dislocation tool)
- 2 Sharp boning or skinning knife
- 3 Clean processing table or board
- 4 Clean bucket or waste container
- 5 Hose or water source
- 6 Cooler with ice or ice water bath
- 7 Gloves (optional, but recommended)
- 8 Clean towels or paper towels

■ Step 1: Preparation

- 1 Choose a calm time of day, and avoid feeding the rabbit 12–24 hours prior to processing.
- 2 Set up your stations: You'll need an area for dispatch, hanging/skinning, gutting, and chilling.
- 3 Sanitize all tools and surfaces.

■ Step 2: Humane Dispatch (Using a Dispatcher Tool)

- 1 Restrain the rabbit gently, holding it by the hind legs or cradling it calmly.
- 2 Position the dispatcher tool at the base of the skull, just behind the ears.
- 3 Firmly press down and pull the body backward, quickly and cleanly separating the skull from the spine.
- 4 Confirm lack of movement, then proceed to bleed out immediately.
- 5 This method is quick, humane, and minimizes stress when done correctly.

■ Step 3: Bleeding Out

- 1 Hang the rabbit by the hind legs or lay it on a clean surface.
- 2 Make a small cut across the throat or near the heart to allow blood to drain.
- 3 Allow 1–2 minutes for complete bleed-out.

■ Step 4: Skinning

- 1 Hang the rabbit by the hind legs using a gambrel or hook.
- 2 Cut around both hind legs, just above the hock joint.
- 3 Slice down the inside of each leg to the tail.
- 4 Cut through the tail base, then begin peeling the skin downward like a sleeve.
- 5 Work carefully over the front legs and head—you can either leave the head or remove it.

■ Step 5: Evisceration (Gutting)

- 1 Lay the skinned rabbit on a clean surface or keep it hanging.
- 2 Make a shallow cut just above the genitals, being careful not to puncture the intestines.
- 3 Open the abdominal cavity carefully, working up toward the ribcage.
- 4 Remove the intestines, stomach, and bladder in one motion.
- 5 Reach up into the chest cavity and pull out the heart, lungs, and liver.
- 6 Separate and save edible organs (liver, heart, kidneys) if desired.
- 7 Important: Discard the green gallbladder (on the liver) carefully—if it bursts, it can ruin the meat.

■ Step 6: Rinse and Chill

- 1 Rinse the carcass inside and out with cool, clean water.
- 2 Pat dry with paper towels or clean cloth.
- 3 Place immediately in a cooler or ice water bath to bring internal temp below 40°F (4°C).
- 4 Chill for at least 12–24 hours before freezing or cooking.

■ Step 7: Packaging

- 1 Once rested, portion or leave whole depending on preference.
- 2 Vacuum seal or wrap tightly in plastic wrap and freezer paper.
- 3 Label with date and weight, then freeze.

■ Tips for Better Processing:

- 1 Process rabbits between 8–12 weeks old for best meat quality.
- 2 Don't rush—smooth, confident movements reduce mess and stress.
- 3 Clean your work area thoroughly after processing.
- 4 Compost non-meat waste or freeze and feed to other livestock (if appropriate).